

What Is Existence?

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The question: What is Existence? What exists? Does the thing that exists begin at some time?

This study reviews these questions from the standpoint of **Madhyasth Darshan** (Co-existentialism), then compares its answer with **Advaita Vedanta** and selected **modern philosophical and scientific approaches** to physical reality, consciousness, and selfhood.

Quick Glossary

Term	Plain meaning
Existence (<i>astitva</i>)	In Madhyasth Darshan: beingness (<i>hona</i>) and indestructibility (<i>anashita</i>), always present as coexistence (<i>saha-astitva</i>).
Coexistence (<i>saha-astitva</i>)	Reality as Omnipresence (<i>satta</i>) and all units (<i>ikai</i>) inseparably present together.
Omnipresence / Space / Brahma / Satta	The all-pervasive, formless, non-transforming reality in which all units (<i>ikai</i>) are saturated (<i>samprikt</i> — submerged, soaked, surrounded: <i>dooba</i> , <i>bheega</i> , <i>gira</i>). The published translation also uses Omnipotence, Uniform/Equilibrium Energy, Space (<i>akasha</i>), Knowledge (<i>gyan</i>), Consciousness, God, and Absolute Energy for this same reality. This paper standardizes on “Omnipresence” as the primary English term and treats the other names as quotations from the source. “Consciousness” here is one name for this pervasive reality and must not be read as a knowing subject — sentience (<i>chaitanya</i>) proper belongs to the sentient unit (<i>jeevan</i>). See §1.6 for the tension this naming creates.
Unit (<i>ikai</i>)	A countable, bounded entity in nature, whether insentient (<i>jada</i>) or sentient (<i>chaitanya</i>).
Jeevan (Sentient Self)	The sentient self: a real, immortal, constitutionally complete unit (<i>gathanpurna parmanu</i>) that works through the body (<i>shareer</i>).
Jada / *Chaitanya*	Insentient and sentient nature (<i>prakriti</i>).

Term	Plain meaning
Saturation (<i>samprikt</i>)	The source's term for how units are held in Omnipresence. Treated in this paper as a metaphor requiring ontological specification (see §1.2).
<i>Atman</i> / * Brahman *	In Advaita Vedanta: the Self and the one ultimate reality, finally identical.
Mithya	In Advaita: the world as dependent appearance, strictly <i>sad-asad-anirvacaniya</i> (indeterminable as either real or unreal).
Sat-Chit-Ananda	In Advaita: the threefold nature of Brahman / the true Self — being (<i>sat</i>), consciousness (<i>chit</i>), bliss (<i>ananda</i>).
Satkaryavada	The Vedantic doctrine that the effect pre-exists in its cause (the pot is already clay). Relevant to the causation discussion in §1.3.
Physicalism	The modern view that every real concrete phenomenon is physical.
Panpsychism	The view that experientiality belongs, at least in primitive form, to fundamental physical reality.
Illusionism	The view that phenomenal consciousness, as usually conceived, is an illusion or misdescription.
Strong / weak emergence	Strong emergence: a higher-level property that is not deducible from, and adds something to, its lower-level base. Weak emergence: a higher-level pattern fully fixed by its base. Relevant to §1.5 and §3.3.

1. The Madhyasth Darshan Answer

The claim in one sentence: Existence (*astitva*) is the eternally present coexistence (*saha-astitva*) of formless Omnipresence (*satta*) and countless sentient (*chaitanya*) and insentient (*jada*) units (*ikai*) held within it; what exists never arises from non-existence (*abhava*) and is never annihilated, though units undergo motion, transformation, development, and awakening.

1.1 The Coexistential Structure: Space (*Satta*) and Nature (*Prakriti*)

Madhyasth Darshan does not define existence (*astitva*) as an object among objects, nor as a mental category imposed by a knower. It defines existence as the inseparable presentness of formless Omnipresence (*satta*) and formful nature (*prakriti*).

SB gives the most compressed formulation:

“What is evident is that consciousness and matter are inseparably present. Upon examining their fundamental nature, we learn that all of existence is essentially nature (matter) saturated in Omnipotence (consciousness). Here, ‘seeing’ is intended in the sense of understanding. Since nature saturated in Omnipotence is inseparably present, existence itself is eternally manifest in the form of coexistence.” - SB, p. 48

A note on the word “consciousness” in the translation. The published translation lists several names for the pervasive reality (*Satta / Vyapak*): Uniform Energy, Space (*akasha*), Knowledge (*gyan*), Consciousness, Omnipresence, Eternity, God, and Absolute Energy. The parenthetical “(consciousness)” therefore labels the all-pervasive reality, not a personal knowing mind. Sentience as the activity of a knower (*chaitanya*) is the status of *jeevan* (the sentient unit), not of Omnipresence (*satta*) itself. This distinction is essential, and it also generates a genuine tension in the source, addressed directly in §1.6.

The same passage rejects two familiar origin stories:

1. Matter (*jada*) does not arise from Omnipresence (*satta*).
2. Omnipresence (*satta*) does not arise from matter (*jada*).

The alternative is not creation of one from the other, but inseparable presentness, expressed in the language of “Realisation Knowledge” (*anubhav jnan*):

“Sentient and insentient nature saturated in Omnipotence. The countless sentient and insentient units are saturated in Omnipotence (Omnipresence).” - MVD, p. 11

“All units saturated in the Omnipresence (permeative and transparent) have form, properties, essential nature & dharma, and have inherent orderliness & participate in overall orderliness.” - MVD, p. 11

Existence thus has two inseparable aspects:

1. **Omnipresence (*Satta / Vyapak*):** The formless, all-pervasive, non-transforming, immeasurable reality. It is described as actionless energy (*kriya-shunya urja*): it performs no actions, yet its permeative presence is the ground in which nature is energized, regulated, and conserved.

“Omnipotence is not confined within any dimension of length or breadth, nor can any measure be established for it; therefore, Omnipotence is all-pervasive.” - SB, p. 49

“Knowledge itself is the omnipresent Omnipotence. This itself is referred to as Space.” - MVD, p. 35

2. Units of Nature (*Ikai*): The formful, active, countable, bounded entities. Units are not illusions in Omnipresence; they have determinate reality and remain surrounded, submerged, and soaked in it.

“Nature, saturated in Omnipotence, exists as countless units. Each unit, being saturated in Omnipotence, remains surrounded, submerged, and soaked in it.” - SB, p. 48

1.2 What Kind of Relation Is “Saturation”? (*Satta* and *Ikai*)

The source describes units as *samprikt* — soaked, submerged, surrounded — in Omnipresence. This is a vivid image, but an image is not yet an ontological relation, and the paper’s central claim (“coexistence”) stands or falls on what this relation actually is. Three candidate readings can be set aside, and a fourth proposed.

Not constitution. Omnipresence is not the stuff units are made of. Units have their own form, properties, and *dharma* (MVD, p. 11); Omnipresence is formless and non-transforming. If units were made of Omnipresence, their transformation would be transformation of it, which the texts deny.

Not inherence (*samavaya*). In the Nyaya-Vaisheshika sense, inherence binds a property to its substance. But Omnipresence is not a property the units possess, nor are units properties of Omnipresence. The relation is mutual and symmetric in a way inherence is not.

Not superimposition (*adhyasa*). This is the decisive contrast with Advaita. For Advaita, the world’s apparent location “in” Brahman is *adhyasa* — a false attribution later sublated. Madhyasth Darshan explicitly refuses this: units are real and perpetual, never sublated. So saturation cannot be *adhyasa*.

Proposed reading: pervasive co-location with energetic dependence. The most defensible reading is that Omnipresence is the omnipresent medium in which every unit is necessarily situated (co-location), and from which every unit draws the regulatory and conserving “energy ground” that keeps it in orderly existence (dependence), without Omnipresence acting, transforming, or being consumed. The relation is therefore one-directionally dependent (units depend on the medium; the medium does not depend on any unit) yet ontologically non-reductive (neither is the other).

The “actionless energy” paradox. This reading exposes a problem the source-language papers over: Omnipresence is called energy and credited with energizing, regulating, and conserving nature, yet is also called actionless (*kriya-shunya*) and non-transforming. Ordinarily, to energize or regulate is to act. The paper’s most charitable resolution is to read “energy” here not as a capacity to do work (the physics sense) but as an enabling condition — the way a field of space “permits” motion without itself moving, or the way the rules of a game constrain play without making any move. On this reading “actionless energy” means: the standing condition under which units are able to act, persist, and stay orderly. This is coherent, but it is a substantive interpretive commitment, not something the texts state outright, and it should be flagged as such rather than smoothed over.

1.3 Causation Within Coexistence

The origination question (“nothing comes from non-being”) is not the same as the causation question (“what does the causal work when units transform?”). The source is strong on the first and nearly silent on the second; this paper makes the gap explicit.

If Omnipresence is timeless and actionless, it cannot be an efficient cause of change. Causal work must therefore be horizontal — unit acting on unit — while Omnipresence functions as the standing condition (in the sense of §1.2) that makes orderly interaction possible and conserves what exists. This yields a two-level causal picture:

1. **Conditioning level (Omnipresence):** non-acting, non-temporal, conserving. It does not push or pull; it grounds and sustains.
2. **Operative level (units):** acting, temporal, transforming. All efficient causation, development, and awakening happen here.

Comparison with *satkaryavada*. Advaita (following Sankhya’s vocabulary) holds *satkaryavada*: the effect pre-exists in the cause — the pot is already present in the clay. The clay-pot analogy you find in the *Vivekachudamani* (quoted in §2.3) is precisely a *satkaryavada* illustration deployed to show that effects are non-different from their material cause (and hence, for Advaita, ultimately Brahman). Madhyasth Darshan needs a different causal doctrine, because it denies a single material cause for everything. Its picture is closer to a transformation realism: real units with determinate natures interact and reconfigure, and “nothing is annihilated” guarantees that every transformation conserves an underlying reality (*vastu*) even as configurations (*roop*) change. This is a *parinamavada*-like (real-transformation) view at the level of units, combined with conservation — and it should be named as such to distinguish it cleanly from both Advaita’s *vivartavada* (apparent transformation) and Sankhya’s *satkaryavada*.

1.4 The Ontological Orders and Realist Relations of Nature

Nature (*prakriti*) does not exist as an amorphous mass, but as countless physical (*jada*) and sentient (*chaitanya*) units.

“Existence is not just physicochemical matter, but all physical, chemical and jeevan entities are inseparably present in Omnipresence.” - MVD, *The Alternative*, point 7

This is why the human being is understood as a joint form of a physical body (*shareer*) and a sentient self (*jeevan*):

“Brahma (Omnipotence) is omnipresent, and jeevan-clouds are many.” - MVD, p. 13

“The grandeur of humans as a joint form of jeevan and body.” - MVD, p. 13

Nature is organized into four real, objective **Ontological Orders** (*chaar avastha*), each defined by its innateness and purpose (*dharma*):

1. **Material Order (*Padarth Avastha*):** Bounded physical and chemical units (atoms, molecules, rocks). Its dharma is bare existence (*astitva / hona*).
2. **Pranic / Bio Order (*Pran Avastha*):** Organic cells, plants, vegetation. Its dharma is growth and biological propagation (*pushti / dharana*).
3. **Animal Order (*Jeev Avastha*):** Animals (body + *jeevan*). Its dharma is the expectation of alive-ness (*jeene ki aasha*).
4. **Knowledge / Human Order (*Gyan Avastha*):** Humans (body + *jeevan*). Its dharma is the expectation of continuous happiness and right-living (*sukh-dharmita*).

Why the orders matter for the argument. These orders are not decoration: they are where “development without creation from nothing” (§1.5) becomes concrete. Each order is a real, stable plateau of organization that the next order presupposes and builds upon, so the upward movement from matter to human is development within coexistence, not the appearance of new substance. The orders also carry the paper’s ethical claim: because existence is coexistence, units exist in objective relations of complementarity (*poorakata*) and orderliness (*vyavastha*):

“Since existence is coexistence, complementarity and mutual recognition are eternally established.” - SB, p. 49

Relations (*sambandh*) and values (*mulya*) are therefore ontologically real, perpetual structural aspects of coexistence. In the human order, values like trust (*vishvas*), respect (*samman*), and gratitude (*kritagyata*) are the objective recognition and fulfilment of these existential relations. Unlike physicalism (which tends to treat values as brain-model

projections) or Advaita (which treats relations as provisional appearances), Madhyasth Darshan grounds ethical value in the actual structure of existence.

1.5 Development and Awakening — and the Emergence Problem

While Madhyasth Darshan rejects creation from nothing, it gives a developmental account of how an atom (*parmanu*) reaches sentient status. This is the transition to constitutional completeness (*gathanpurnata*), forming the immortal sentient self (*jeevan*):

“In the course of an atom’s development, there comes a stage when the required number of particles for its constitution are all integrated, and at that point, it becomes constitutionally complete. Constitutional completeness signifies satisfaction within, by, and for that constitution. This is the immortality of the result, and the attainment of sentient status.” - SB, p. 59

“All types of atoms, including constitutionally complete ones, are eternally present through the natural law of coexistence in existence.” - SB, p. 59

The emergence tension (stated, not hidden). This is the most exposed point in the whole system, and honesty requires naming it. The account says a quantitative change — the right number of particles integrating — produces a qualitative change of kind: insentient becomes sentient. That is a strong-emergence claim. Yet in §3.3 the paper leans on Strawson’s argument that experience cannot emerge from the wholly non-experiential. Madhyasth Darshan therefore appears to use against reductive physicalism the very move it relies on for the origin of *jeevan*.

There are three possible replies, and the paper should commit to one rather than leave the tension dangling:

1. **(a) Latency reply.** Sentience does not emerge from nothing; the potential for sentience is “eternally present through the natural law of coexistence” (SB, p. 59). Constitutional completeness is the actualization of a standing potential, not strong emergence. This is the most consistent reply, but it owes an account of where that potential “resides” before completeness — in the units, in Omnipresence, or in the law of coexistence itself?
2. **(b) Threshold-as-form reply.** What changes at completeness is not the addition of a new ingredient but the achievement of a form (a stable self-maintaining constitution). Sentience is identified with that form’s “satisfaction within, by, and for that constitution.” This makes sentience a structural achievement, closer to weak emergence — but then it concedes ground to the self-model theorists of §3.1.

3. **(c) Bite-the-bullet reply.** Accept that this is genuine strong emergence and that the Strawson borrowing in §3.3 must be qualified: Madhyasth Darshan agrees experience cannot emerge from the wholly non-experiential, and so must hold that the pre-complete atom is not wholly non-experiential — which pushes back toward (a).

The honest conclusion is that (a) is the only reply that keeps the system internally consistent with its use of Strawson, and that it is currently an assertion about latent potential rather than an explained mechanism. This is flagged again as an open problem in §5.2.

1.6 The “Knowledge but not Knower” Tension

The glossary insists that “Consciousness,” as a name for Omnipresence, must not be read as a knowing subject. Yet the source also says, flatly: “Knowledge itself is the omnipresent Omnipotence” (MVD, p. 35). So Omnipresence is called Knowledge (*gyan*) while being denied the activity of knowing. This is a real tension in the source, not merely a translation artifact, and the stronger scholarly move is to flag it rather than dissolve it in a glossary footnote.

A charitable reading: *gyan* here names a condition of intelligibility — reality is such that it can be known, is orderly, transparent, lawful — rather than an act of cognition. On this reading Omnipresence is “Knowledge” the way a perfectly legible text is “meaning” even when no one is reading it. The knowing act (*chaitanya*) still belongs only to *jeevan*. This is coherent, but readers should be told it is an interpretation, and that a careless reading of MVD p. 35 collapses straight into Advaita’s *chit* (Brahman as awareness itself) — exactly the identification this paper otherwise resists.

1.7 The Mereology and Identity of *Jeevan*

Two questions the source leaves open, both logically prior to the *jeevan*–body interaction problem.

Is *jeevan* simple or composite? *Jeevan* is called a “constitutionally complete atom” (*gathanpurna parmanu*), which suggests a structured composite (it is complete because the right number of particles integrated). But it is also called indivisible and immortal. A composite is, in principle, decomposable; so its claimed indestructibility needs a ground. The most consistent reading is that *jeevan*’s “indivisibility” is functional (the constitution is self-maintaining and does not spontaneously lose completeness) rather than mereological (having no parts). If so, “immortal” means “does not lose constitutional completeness,” which is a weaker and more defensible claim than “has no parts and therefore cannot perish.”

What makes this *jeevan* the same *jeevan* over time? Advaita dissolves individuation (individuality is ignorance); physicalism grounds identity in bodily/psychological continuity. Madhyasth Darshan asserts that *jeevan* persists across bodily death and re-association but offers no explicit criterion of identity. An eternalist individual-self ontology needs one. The candidate implied by the texts is continuity of constitution — the same constitutionally complete configuration persists — but this needs to be stated and defended, because

constitution-identity over a gap of embodiment (death to re-association) is exactly where the criterion is hardest.

1.8 Does Existence Begin? Time (*Kaal*) and Conservation

For Madhyasth Darshan, existence does not begin in the sense of coming from absolute non-existence (*abhava*). What exists has always existed, though its form, configuration, and states are in constant flux:

“That which exists continues to be, and that which was not, does not come into existence. Therefore, existence will remain as it is till eternity.” - SB, p. 49

“Nothing arrives at birth nor does anything depart with death. All that is, exists forever.” - JV, p. 20

Time (*kaal*) is not an independent cosmic dimension or background substance. It is the human measurement of the activity, change, and motion (*kriya / gati*) of units. Because formless Omnipresence is actionless and non-transforming, it is timeless; time applies only to the transformations of active units in nature.

This ontology distinguishes absolute annihilation (*vinasha*) from physical transformation (*roopantaran*). An entity changes configuration, but its underlying substance (*vastu*) is never destroyed:

“A piece of charcoal continues to exist in other forms even after burning it.” - JV, p. 20

“At the fundamental level, a ‘reality’ never gets annihilated.” - JV, p. 20

The result is a conservation-based ontology:

1. Existence (*astitva*) as coexistence (*saha-astitva*) is beginningless and endless.
2. Omnipresence (*satta*) does not begin, change, or end.
3. Units (*ikai*) do not arise from non-being (*abhava*) and do not vanish into it.
4. Particular bodies (*shareer*), configurations, relations, and states do begin and end.
5. Development (*vikas*) and awakening (*jagriti*) are real, but are not creation out of nothing.

Question	Madhyasth Darshan answer
Did existence begin?	No. Existence (<i>astitva</i>) is eternally present coexistence (<i>saha-astitva</i>).

Question	Madhyasth Darshan answer
Did units begin from non-existence?	No. “That which was not, does not come into existence” (<i>abhava</i>).
Do bodies begin and end?	Yes. Birth and death are events at the level of body (<i>shareer</i>) and association.
Does <i>jeevan</i> begin at birth?	No. <i>Jeevan</i> is immortal; birth and death are occurrences.
Does sentient status have a developmental account?	Yes. Constitutional completeness (<i>gathanpurnata</i>) is attainment of sentient status — within eternal coexistence, not as creation from nothing (see the emergence tension, §1.5).

1.9 The Perpetual World: *Brahma Satya Hai, Jagat Satat Hai*

MVD compresses the ontology into one line:

“**Brahma is truth, the world is perpetual.**” - MVD, p. 13

This is a metaphysical commitment: Brahma (Omnipresence) and the world of units are both real, neither cancelled by the other. If the world is perpetual (*satat*), then matter (*jada*) is not ultimately negated, relationships (*sambandh*) are not merely provisional, and humane conduct (*manaviya aacharan*) is not merely preparatory to escape from the world.

Madhyasth Darshan thus rejects two reductions that would split this inseparable whole:

1. **Material reductionism:** only physicochemical matter (*jada*) exists.
2. **World-negating spiritualism:** only the formless ground (*satta*) is finally real, and the world is diminished to mere appearance.

Its positive claim: Brahma is real, the world is real, and their inseparable presentness is coexistence (*saha-astitva*).

2. The Advaita Vedanta Answer

The claim in one sentence: Existence in the strictest sense is Brahman alone, one without a second; the world of names, forms, bodies, and relations is *mithya*, a dependent appearance, and the true Self is neither born nor destroyed because it is identical with Brahman.

A note on fairness before proceeding: Advaita does not deny the empirical world; it subordinates it. The world is *mithya* — strictly indeterminable as real or unreal (*sad-asad-anirvacaniya*), not sheer nothing. The two-truths framework (*vyavahara / paramartha*) and the *mithya* doctrine are related but distinct tools, and this section keeps them apart.

2.1 Existence Alone, One Without a Second

“In the beginning this was Existence alone, One only, without a second.”

- CU 6.2.1

Shankara glosses *sat* as:

“mere Existence, a thing that is subtle, without distinction, all pervasive, one, taintless, partless, consciousness” - CU 6.2.1, Shankara commentary

The text rejects existence arising from non-existence:

“By what logic can existence verily come out of non-existence? But surely, o good looking one, in the beginning all this was Existence, One only, without a second.” - CU 6.2.2

2.2 Sat-Chit-Ananda: Being, Consciousness, Bliss

A second classical formulation names existence not only as *sat* — bare being — but as **Sat-Chit-Ananda**: being-consciousness-bliss. These are not three realities added together; Brahman is one partless reality whose nature is expressed in three inseparable names.

“Brahman is Truth, Knowledge, and Infinity.” - TU 2.1.1

Shankara’s tradition reads *satyam* as being/reality, *jnanam* as consciousness, and *anantam* as the infinite. The *anandamaya* passage (TU 2.5) leads the seeker beyond even bliss-as-sheath to the Self beyond all coverings. Shankara states the mature formula in the *Vivekachudamani*:

“By that alone he comes to know his own Self as Existence-Knowledge-Bliss Absolute and becomes happy.” - VC, v. 152

The same triad recurs at v. 217. In this scheme:

1. **Sat** — Brahman is existence; to exist absolutely is to be Brahman.
2. **Chit** — consciousness is the very nature of reality and Self, not a function of brain or mind.
3. **Ananda** — bliss is the intrinsic fullness of the Self, free from lack and dependence on objects.

So for Advaita the answer to “what is existence?” is concentrated: existence is the one reality that is being, consciousness, and bliss without a second.

2.3 What Exists in Advaita?

Strict answer: Brahman alone exists absolutely. The world is not sheer nothing, nor absolutely real; it is *mithya*.

“A firm conviction of the mind to the effect that Brahman is real and the universe unreal, is designated as discrimination (Viveka) between the Real and the unreal.” - VC, v. 20

“The individual soul is itself and directly the Supreme Brahman, and nothing else.” - VC, v. 216

The clay-pot analogy (a *satkaryavada* illustration; see §1.3):

“All modifications of clay, such as the jar, which are always accepted by the mind as real, are (in reality) nothing but clay. Similarly, this entire universe which is produced from the real Brahman, is Brahman Itself and nothing but That.” - VC, v. 251

Level	What exists?	Status of world
Empirical (<i>vyavahara</i>)	Bodies, minds, causes, effects, duties, scriptures, practices	Operationally valid
Absolute (<i>paramartha</i>)	Brahman alone	World is <i>mithya</i> , dependent appearance

2.4 Does What Exists Begin?

Brahman does not begin: it is beginningless, partless, actionless, non-dual. The universe as name-form has origination at the empirical level, but its ultimate truth is Brahman. Creation is therefore not production from nothing; it is manifestation of names and forms on the basis of Brahman (*vivartavada* — apparent transformation, contrasted with the *parinamavada* of §1.3).

“The Supreme Brahman is, like the sky, pure, absolute, infinite, motionless and changeless, devoid of interior or exterior, the One Existence, without a second, and one’s own Self.” - VC, v. 393

3. Modern Philosophical and Scientific Approaches

The claim in one sentence: Modern thought has no single answer to existence, but it imposes one consistent pressure — a high burden of proof on any posit beyond the physical — and its debates on consciousness and selfhood show that “what exists” remains contested.

The references here are mainly philosophy of mind and cognitive science; §3.5 adds one cited cosmology source (Ashtekar and Singh 2011 on loop quantum cosmology). Conformal cyclic and eternal-inflation models are still mentioned only as widely reported physics, without local sources in this paper’s bibliography.

3.1 Standard Physicalism: Concrete Reality Is Physical

“I take physicalism to be the view that every real, concrete phenomenon in the universe is...physical.” - Strawson 2006, p. 2

On this view, what exists are physical things, events, fields, organisms, brains, and processes. Minds and selves are functions, organizations, models, or processes of physical systems. Self-model theories follow this line:

“minimal selfhood emerges as the result” - Limanowski and Blankenburg 2013, p. 1

“these accounts propose to ‘understand the elusive sense of minimal self in terms of having internal models that successfully predict or match the sensory consequences of our own movement, our intentions in action, and our sensory input’.” - Limanowski and Blankenburg 2013, p. 3

This is nearly the opposite of the *jeevan* ontology. For Madhyasth Darshan the self is a real sentient unit using the body; for self-model theory the self is a model generated by embodied prediction. Note, though, the awkward proximity flagged in §1.5: the “threshold-as-form” reading of constitutional completeness moves Madhyasth Darshan uncomfortably close to “self as self-maintaining structure.”

3.2 The Hard Problem: Experience Resists Reduction

“The really hard problem of consciousness is the problem of experience. When we think and perceive, there is a whirl of information-processing, but there is also a subjective aspect.” - Chalmers 1995, p. 3

“It is widely agreed that experience arises from a physical basis, but we have no good explanation of why and how it so arises.” - Chalmers 1995, p. 3

“the fact that an organism has conscious experience at all means, basically, that there is something it is like to be that organism.” - Nagel 1974, p. 1

For Madhyasth Darshan this is evidence that body-only ontology is incomplete. The physicalist reply — that an explanatory gap is not proof of *jeevan* — is the central disagreement, and the paper should grant that an explanatory gap is, indeed, not by itself an existence proof (see §5.2).

3.3 Panpsychist Physicalism: Experience as Fundamental

“Full recognition of the reality of experience, then, is the obligatory starting point for any remotely realistic version of physicalism.” - Strawson 2006, p. 2

“Experiential phenomena cannot be emergent from wholly non-experiential phenomena.” - Strawson 2006, p. 12

“Real physicalism, realistic physicalism, entails panpsychism.” - Strawson 2006, p. 12

This is closer to Madhyasth Darshan than reductive physicalism, since both refuse experience-from-dead-matter. But the agreement cuts both ways. Strawson’s anti-emergence principle is exactly what makes the *gathanpurnata* account of §1.5 hard: if experience cannot emerge from the wholly non-experiential, then either the pre-complete atom is not wholly non-experiential (latency reply, §1.5a), or the threshold account is a form of the emergence Strawson rejects. Madhyasth Darshan also differs from Strawson in scope: it does not say every particle is a subject; sentience is the status of constitutionally complete atoms only. The two views share an enemy (dead-matter reductionism) but not a metaphysic.

3.4 Illusionism: Phenomenal Consciousness as Misdescription

“Another approach, which holds that phenomenal consciousness is an illusion and aims to explain why it seems to exist.” - Frankish 2016, p. 1

“illusionists deny the existence of phenomenal consciousness properly so-called, but do not deny the existence of a form of consciousness” - Frankish 2016, p. 8

Madhyasth Darshan regards this as another reductionism: it treats experience, valuation, aspiration, and realization as activities of *jeevan*, not brain-model illusions. Illusionism matters because it shows how far naturalism will go to preserve a physicalist ontology.

3.5 Physical Cosmology: Does the Physical Universe Begin?

The standard cosmological model suggests the observable universe — including space and time — had a beginning at a singularity ~13.8 billion years ago. Taken as the absolute origin of all physical reality, this would challenge a beginningless ontology. However, because General Relativity breaks down at the Planck scale, several non-singular models have been proposed:

1. **Loop Quantum Cosmology (Big Bounce):** quantum-gravity effects replace the singularity with a “bounce” from a prior contracting universe. Ashtekar and Singh summarize the program:

“For matter satisfying the usual energy conditions any time a curvature invariant grows to the Planck scale, quantum geometry effects dilute it, thereby resolving singularities of general relativity.” - Ashtekar and Singh 2011, abstract

In the homogeneous isotropic models they review, the classical big-bang is replaced by a quantum bounce: the matter-density observable that diverges at the singularity is bounded by quantum dynamics (Ashtekar and Singh 2011, §III).

2. **Conformal Cyclic Cosmology (Penrose):** an infinite sequence of aeons, each aeon’s far future becoming the next’s hot dense start.
3. **Eternal Inflation / Multiverse:** our bubble began, but the eternally inflating background does not.

Use with caution. These are competing speculative programs, not consensus. Even loop quantum cosmology remains a research program, not settled science. The most this paper should claim is a conceptual resonance: several serious research programs are comfortable with a beginningless physical substrate even when local configurations begin and end —

which is consonant with the claim that nature (*prakriti*) is perpetual (*satat*). It does not establish it.

3.6 Does What Exists Begin, in Modern Thought?

1. **Physicalism & cosmology:** organisms, stars, and local universes begin and end; the deeper substrate may or may not be beginningless — unsettled.
2. **Self-model theories:** the self begins developmentally; no eternal individual self.
3. **Panpsychism:** experientiality may be fundamental; particular minds still depend on organization.
4. **Illusionism:** phenomenal consciousness “never begins” only because, in the realist sense, it does not exist; what begins are quasi-phenomenal states.

Against all of these, Madhyasth Darshan makes a stronger claim: coexistence is eternal, units are not annihilated, and *jeevan* is immortal. This eternalism is consistent with conservation principles and beginningless cosmological models, but its claims about individual immortality and constitutional completeness remain distinct metaphysical assertions not validated by current science.

4. Comparison

This section is purely descriptive; evaluation is reserved for §5.

Question	Madhyasth Darshan	Advaita Vedanta	Modern physicalist approaches
What is existence?	Eternally present coexistence: Omnipresence plus all units held in it.	Brahman / Existence alone, one without a second.	Concrete physical reality, studied empirically.
What exists absolutely?	Omnipresence and real units, sentient and insentient.	Brahman alone.	Usually the physical; experience disputed.
Is the world real?	Yes. “Brahma is truth, the world is perpetual.”	Empirically valid but ultimately <i>mithya</i> .	Yes, as physical reality.
Does existence begin?	No. What exists does not come from non-existence.	Brahman does not begin.	Particular systems begin and end; cosmology unsettled.
Does the individual self begin?	<i>Jeevan</i> does not begin at birth or die with the body.	<i>Jiva</i> is ultimately Brahman; individuality is ignorance.	Self develops as biological/cognitive process.

Question	Madhyasth Darshan	Advaita Vedanta	Modern physicalist approaches
What changes?	Forms, bodies, configurations, awakening.	Names and forms appear and are sublated; Brahman is changeless.	Physical and mental configurations change.
Causal doctrine	Real transformation of units + conservation (<i>parinama</i> -like).	Apparent transformation (<i>vivartavada</i>).	Physical causation; mechanism.
Method of knowing	Study, realization, behavior, experiment.	Scripture, reasoning, contemplative discrimination.	Observation, modelling, public evidence.
Ethical consequence	Humane conduct evidences understanding of coexistence.	Ethics prepares the mind for liberation.	Ethics via naturalism, social/normative theory.

The Sat-Chit-Ananda contrast, distributed

Advaita's Sat-Chit-Ananda and Madhyasth Darshan's coexistence can sound alike — both speak of being, consciousness, and fulfilment. The contrast is over what those words name and whether the world survives them.

For Advaita, *sat*, *chit*, *ananda* are three names for one ultimate reality without a second; the world is finally *mithya*. For Madhyasth Darshan, the same vocabulary is distributed across coexistence, not compressed into one subject:

Concept	Advaita Vedanta (Unified Non-Dualism)	Madhyasth Darshan (Distributed Coexistence)
Sat (Being)	Brahman alone is Sat; the world is a dependent appearance ultimately negated.	Beingness (<i>astitva</i>) is coexistence of formless Omnipresence and countless real units.
Chit (Consciousness)	Pure awareness, identical to the inner Self; the world of names/forms is inert.	Omnipresence is pervasive knowledge/condition-of-intelligibility (§1.6), but active sentience (<i>chaitanya</i>) belongs to the <i>jeevan</i> unit.
Ananda (Bliss)	Intrinsic nature of Brahman; sensory joy is a distorted reflection.	Harmony realized within the awakened <i>jeevan</i> , expressed as humane conduct.

Modern philosophy has no parallel formula: it may treat experience as physical, fundamental, or illusory, but it does not name existence as Sat-Chit-Ananda or as coexistence.

5. Critical Review

5.1 Strengths of the Madhyasth Darshan Position

1. **It answers the three questions directly.** Existence is beingness and indestructibility as coexistence; what exists is Omnipresence and all units; what exists does not begin from non-being.
2. **It avoids world-negation.** “Brahma is truth, the world is perpetual” preserves the reality of nature, society, relationship, and ethical responsibility.
3. **It avoids simple material reductionism.** It refuses to treat consciousness, value, and selfhood as mere byproducts of body-chemistry.
4. **It links ontology and conduct.** If existence is coexistence, human fulfilment must be evidenced as coexistence in behavior, not merely believed.
5. **It is conservation-based.** “Nothing existent is annihilated” gives internal coherence to its account of body, *jeevan*, death, transformation, and development.

5.2 Open Problems for Madhyasth Darshan

1. **The emergence of sentience is unexplained, not merely unmeasured.** The strongest internal tension (§1.5): constitutional completeness must be the actualization of a latent potential rather than strong emergence, or it contradicts the anti-emergence principle borrowed from Strawson. The latency reply keeps the system consistent but currently asserts, rather than explains, where the potential resides before completeness.
2. **The Satta–Ikai relation is a metaphor awaiting an ontology.** “Saturation” needs to be specified (§1.2); “actionless energy that energizes” must be read as enabling condition, not efficient cause, and this reading is interpretive.
3. **The “Knowledge but not knower” tension (§1.6) must be managed,** or Omnipresence collapses into Advaita’s *chit*.
4. **The mereology and identity of *jeevan* (§1.7) need defense:** functional vs. mereological indivisibility, and a criterion of identity across the death-to-re-association gap.
5. **From indestructibility to *jeevan* is not publicly established.** That reality is not annihilated does not by itself prove a distinct sentient unit survives bodily death.
6. **Constitutional completeness is not yet operational.** It is central but not presently measurable in physics or chemistry.

7. **The *jeevan*–body interaction needs articulation.** If *jeevan* drives the body, how does intention become neural and muscular activity?
8. **The evidence standard differs from science.** Realization and behavior are cited; science accepts public behavioral evidence but not private realization as establishing ontology without independent testability.
9. **The “nothing is annihilated” principle and modern physics — handle with care.** Particle–antiparticle annihilation and pair creation are not passages into or out of absolute non-being: in quantum field theory, particles are localized excitations of conserved, all-pervasive fields, and annihilation transforms one excitation (matter) into another (radiation) under strict conservation laws. This is broadly consonant with the claim that fundamental reality (*vastu*) is conserved while configurations (*roop*) transform. But the alignment should not be overstated: fields are not “substances that persist” in quite the sense *vastu* intends, and energy conservation itself is subtle in General Relativity (it is tied, via Noether’s theorem, to time-symmetry that need not hold globally in an expanding spacetime). The right verb is “is consonant with,” not “is supported by.”

5.3 Strengths and Limits of Advaita

Advaita has a powerful answer to non-being (existence cannot arise from non-existence) and a rigorous first-person method of discriminating seer from seen. Its limit, from the Madhyasth perspective, is that making the world *mithya* makes it harder to ground the ultimate reality of relationships, nature, society, and conduct. Advaita’s fair reply: ethics and compassion remain valid at the empirical (*vyavahara*) level, and realization of non-duality deepens rather than weakens them. The Madhyasth counter-reply: an ontology that makes the world *mithya* cannot give the world the same final weight coexistence gives it. This is a genuine disagreement about final ontological status, not a defeat of Advaita on its own terms — and the paper should present it that way.

5.4 Strengths and Limits of Modern Approaches

Modern approaches are strongest where Madhyasth Darshan is weakest: public evidence, empirical correction, cognitive modelling, precise mechanism. Self-model theory explains many features of embodied selfhood without an eternal *jeevan*; illusionism shows how a naturalist can reinterpret even the apparent obviousness of experience. But modern philosophy is not unified: Chalmers and Nagel show experience resists reduction; Strawson shows some physicalists move toward panpsychism. So it is inaccurate to say “modern philosophy has proved the self is only the brain.” It has not — but it has set a high evidential bar for any claim of an immortal sentient unit.

5.5 Two Western Analogues

The philosophy-of-mind sources are not the closest Western kin to Madhyasth Darshan; two others are, and this section now engages them directly.

Whitehead's process philosophy is arguably the closest analogue: plurality is real, relations are ontologically fundamental, and reality is perpetual becoming rather than static substance. His basic units are "actual entities" — "drops of experience, complex and interdependent" (Whitehead 1929, p. 28) — which resemble units-in-relation, and his refusal to bifurcate nature parallels the refusal of both world-negation and matter-only reductionism. The key contrast: Whitehead's occasions are momentary and "perpetually perish" subjectively, gaining "objective immortality" only as data for successors (Whitehead 1929, p. 44), whereas Madhyasth Darshan's *jeevan* is a persisting immortal individual — so the two agree on relational realism but disagree sharply on individual persistence.

"Actual entities 'perpetually perish' subjectively, but are immortal objectively." - Whitehead 1929, p. 44

Neutral monism (Russell, Mach) resembles the account of Omnipresence as a reality that is neither mind nor matter but the common ground of both. Russell holds that mind and matter are "composed of a neutral-stuff which, in isolation, is neither mental nor material" (Russell 1921, Lecture I). Mach likewise denies any "rift between the psychical and the physical": "There is but one kind of elements, out of which this supposed inside and outside are formed" (Mach 1914, Ch. XIV). The contrast: neutral monism typically builds mind and matter out of the neutral stuff, whereas Madhyasth Darshan keeps Omnipresence non-transforming and lets units be real in their own right rather than constructed from the ground.

"Both mind and matter are composed of a neutral-stuff which, in isolation, is neither mental nor material." - Russell 1921, Lecture I

"There is no rift between the psychical and the physical, no inside and outside... There is but one kind of elements, out of which this supposed inside and outside are formed." - Mach 1914, Ch. XIV

5.6 Can These Systems Be Adjudicated at All?

A methodological caveat the paper owes its reader. The three systems do not merely give different answers; they partly use different criteria for what counts as existing — public testability (physicalism), scriptural plus contemplative discrimination (Advaita), and realization-plus-behavior-plus-experiment (Madhyasth Darshan). To that extent they are partially incommensurable, and no single neutral tribunal settles them. What can be done, and what this paper attempts, is narrower: test each for internal consistency, for fit with what

is publicly known, and for whether its distinctive posits are responsibly distinguished from bare assertion. On that triad, Madhyasth Darshan's most exposed point is the emergence of sentience (§1.5); Advaita's is the final status of the world; physicalism's is the hard problem.

6. Conclusion

Madhyasth Darshan's answer to the paper's three questions is exact:

1. **What is Existence?** Eternally present coexistence: formless Omnipresence and formful units inseparably present.
2. **What exists?** Omnipresence exists; countless sentient and insentient units exist; their form, properties, nature, dharma, mutuality, and orderliness exist.
3. **Does what exists begin?** No. What exists does not come from non-existence and is not annihilated. Bodies and configurations begin and end; existence and existent realities persist through transformation.

Its most distinctive formulation —

“Brahma is truth, the world is perpetual.” - MVD, p. 13

— marks the difference from Advaita and physicalism at once: against Advaita, the world is not *mithya*; against physicalism, existence is not merely physicochemical matter; against both, reality is neither world-negation nor matter-only, but coexistence.

The philosophical strength of this view is that it makes the world, relationships, conduct, and ecological responsibility fully real. Its unresolved challenges are now two, and they are different in kind. The evidential challenge — clarifying how *jeevan*, constitutional completeness, and post-death continuity can be studied or responsibly distinguished from metaphysical assertion — is the one the paper already recognized. The internal-coherence challenge — reconciling the developmental origin of sentience with the anti-emergence principle the system relies on, and specifying the Satta-Ikai relation beyond metaphor — is the one this revision brings to the surface. A mature presentation of Madhyasth Darshan will have to meet both, and the most promising route is the “latent potential within the law of coexistence” reading, made explicit and defended rather than assumed.

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